

World in Brief: Trump cancels strikes on Iran; EU calls emergency meeting



Photograph: AFP

Donald Trump cancelled strikes on **Iran**, claiming to have reached the “perimeters” of a [peace deal](#) along with Israel. But the Israeli government has indicated that, if Iran restarts its nuclear or ballistic-missile programmes, Israel will attack “regardless of external commitments”. Iran, meanwhile, maintains there is not yet any agreement around reopening the Strait of Hormuz, on which Mr Trump’s purported deal depends.

The **European Union** called for an emergency meeting on Tuesday to discuss the migrant crisis in Ceuta, a Spanish exclave in North Africa. Earlier, Spain’s prime minister criticised the bloc’s leaders for their “selfish, polarising” response after more than [50,000 people crossed](#) into the territory from Morocco. Spain said almost all of them had since returned.

At least five people have died, with more than 40 missing, after an **Indonesian ferry** caught fire close to the country’s second-largest city. Indonesia’s search and rescue agency reported that the vessel, which was carrying more than 250 passengers, was “almost entirely engulfed in flames” shortly after setting sail from Surabaya in East Java. The cause of the blaze is not yet known.

Two helicopters collided while fighting **wildfires** in **Greece**, killing the two crew members in one of them. Several fires have broken out in Greece this week, which spread over the weekend, fanned by strong winds. Dozens of homes were destroyed near Athens and evacuations were made in several areas. Europe's devastating wildfires this summer have been made worse by low rainfall and historic heatwaves.

Extreme heat in Europe forced **Hungary** to shut its only **nuclear-power station** because drought had brought the Danube river, which supplies water used to cool the facility, to its lowest level in years. The site provides around 40% of Hungary's electricity. The government said it might halt the supply of electricity to the largest users if the grid comes under too much pressure.

At least three people were killed in **Moscow** after a homemade bomb exploded in a restaurant in the heart of Russia's capital. Officials said the device was carried into the venue by a woman and detonated when she was confronted by a security guard. The motive for the attack remains unclear. In [recent years](#) similar bombings, which the Kremlin has blamed on Ukraine, have targeted senior Russian military leaders.

Nirmal Purja, a record-breaking mountaineer, was confirmed killed during a climb in Pakistan, along with nine others. The climbers were caught in an **avalanche** on Thursday while ascending Broad Peak, the world's 12th-tallest mountain. Because of challenging conditions, only some of the bodies have yet been recovered. Mr Purja once held the world record for the fastest ascent of the 14 tallest peaks.

Word of the week: Q-day. What geeks call the moment when the encryption underpinning most online activity will no longer be safe. We explain why it's past time to [upgrade to post-quantum encryption](#).

Tricky talks at OPEC



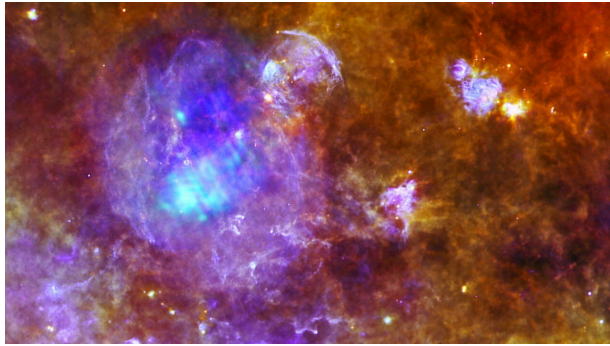
Photograph: Getty Images

On Sunday the Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and its allies, OPEC+, meets to decide oil-production quotas for September. Core members will probably raise output by nearly 188,000 barrels per day (b/d), as in the previous three months, fully unwinding the 1.65m b/d of cuts agreed in 2023.

But the cartel plans to hold its target steady from October to December, which sidesteps a harder question. A further 2m b/d of cuts, agreed in 2022, still need to be unwound, and deciding how much more oil each member gets to produce is a political conundrum.

Some members, such as Iraq, are pushing to produce a bigger share of OPEC's output. The UAE made similar demands for years before [leaving the group](#) in May. The Iran war makes this process [even more uncertain](#), since it continues to curb the spare capacity Gulf members can draw on in the near term. How much the cartel can plausibly deliver depends on diplomatic developments largely beyond its control.

Particle physicists collide in Brazil



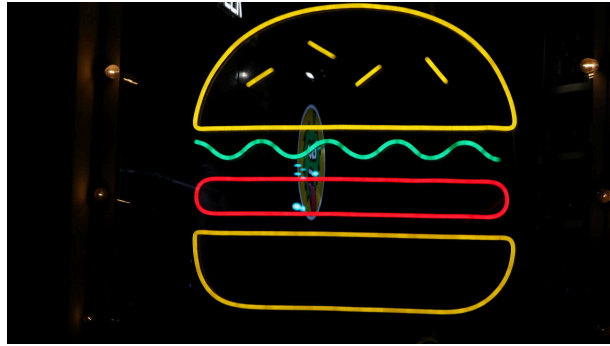
Photograph: Getty Images

Many of the world's most esteemed particle physicists gather in Natal, Brazil, this week for the 43rd International Conference on High Energy Physics. The week-long, biennial event is a key date in the calendars of those who spend their time pondering the universe's smallest stuff.

The programme of 800 talks spans the full spectrum of particle-physics research, including big questions such as what dark matter really is and how gravity works at the subatomic level. There will be presentations of recent experimental findings that could signal [elusive new physics](#). But it will cover more mundane topics too, like how artificial intelligence might be best used to sift through the debris of particle collisions.

Attendees this year may be feeling sombre, though. Last month the Large Hadron Collider fired its last beam for four years. The world's largest particle accelerator is now out of action while it gets upgraded. But another topic on the agenda in Natal is whether the world needs an even bigger one. That might cheer them up.

The Big Mac index turns 40



Photograph: Getty Images

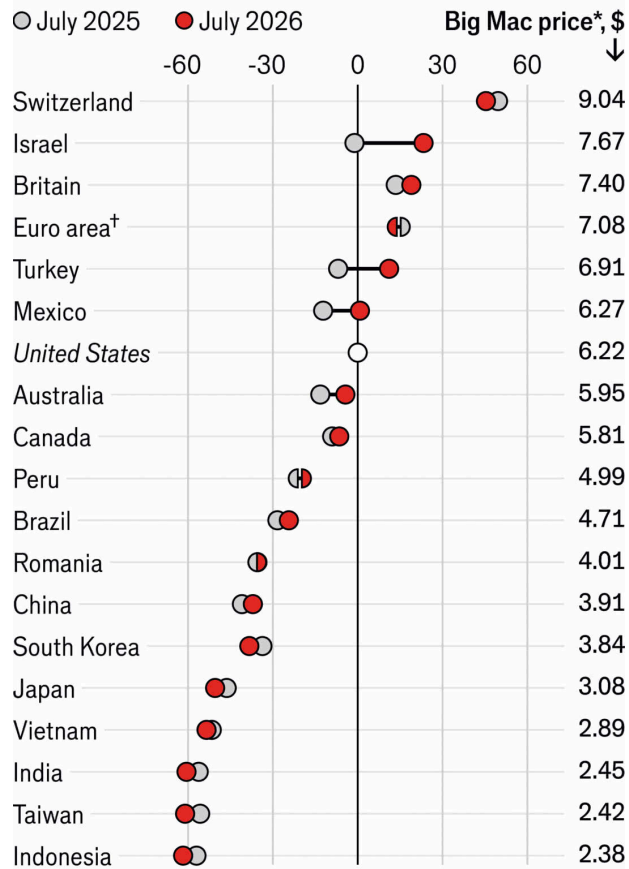
It began as a bit of fun. Forty years ago, an *Economist* writer came up with a simplified measure of purchasing power, using a product sold almost everywhere: [the Big Mac](#). Like a bun-bound basket of goods, its price reflects the cost of 60 ingredients, plus labour, rent and electricity.

Under the theory of purchasing-power parity, the exchange rate between any two countries ought to convert their local Big Mac prices neatly. But this is seldom the case. The difference tells us how much the currency is over- or undervalued. A Swiss Big Mac's price in francs is 1.17 times that of an American one in dollars. But a dollar buys you only SFr0.81 using the actual exchange rate—suggesting the franc is wildly overvalued.

Though it has its critics, over the past four decades our index has appeared in economics textbooks, has been widely imitated and has [kept the score](#) as currencies (and countries) have come and gone. Readers seem to still be lovin' it.

The Big Mac index

Local currency under-/over-valuation
against the dollar, %



*At market exchange rates (July 15th 2026)

[†]Weighted average of member countries

Sources: McDonald's; *The Economist*

Weekend profile: Abdul-Malik al-Houthi, the Yemeni warlord menacing Saudi Arabia



Photograph: Getty Images

In Sana'a, Yemen's capital, pictures of Abdul-Malik al-Houthi are a frequent sight. He glowers from billboards, with a dagger tucked in his belt. Crowds watch his speeches on big screens. His followers wave banners showing his face. Mr Houthi is everywhere—and nowhere. The rebel leader, who has controlled most of north-west Yemen for more than a decade, never appears in public. He holds meetings by video from caves and safe-houses.

Mr Houthi has reason to be cautious. The Houthis, as his militia is known, are among Iran's most battle-hardened allies. In recent years Israel has killed the leaders of other groups in Iran's self-proclaimed "axis of resistance", a network of proxies across the Middle East. Yet Mr Houthi survives. His forces recently [declared a blockade](#) of Saudi Arabia's ports in retaliation for Saudi restrictions on shipping and flights arriving in Yemen. Rebels have in recent weeks fired missiles at Israel and Saudi Arabia and bombed ships in the Red Sea

He was born, probably around 1980, to a cleric from Yemen's Zaydi Shia minority. The sect chafed at the influence of Sunni preachers in the north of the country, many of whom were paid by

Saudi Arabia. By the 1990s Hussein al-Houthi, Mr Houthi's older brother, had built up a large network of followers. He admired Iran and its revolutionary ideology. In 1994 Husayn began sending students to Iran, where some were thought to have made contact with the regime's security services. He came up with the Houthis' slogan: "Death to America, death to Israel, a curse upon the Jews, victory to Islam."

In the early 2000s the group rebelled against the Saudi-backed government in the north. Husayn was killed and Mr Houthi took over. As Yemen slid towards civil war, he proved his mettle. He visited the front lines and modelled himself on Hassan Nasrallah, the leader of Hizbullah, who was killed by Israel in 2024. He studied the Lebanese leader's rousing rhetorical style. Mr Houthi also rules as a tyrant. Children are forced to study the group's doctrine or risk being denied food. His nephew, Ali al-Houthi, is in charge of the group's secret police. His niece, Fatima, is in charge of the Zaynabiyat, its all-female brigade.

Military campaigns to oust Mr Houthi by Saudi Arabia and its allies have all failed. When the Houthis took control of Sana'a in 2014 they were armed with basic weapons. They now have anti-ship missiles, ballistic missiles and drones, thanks to their alliance with Iran. "Our Yemeni people repay loyalty with loyalty," said Mr Houthi in a speech in March, as America and Israel attacked Iran. Whether his foes can do anything to stop him is far from clear.

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Andreas Gotterba, Santa Clara, California

Agnes Wilkie, Kilberry, Scotland

Ayako Fukui, Okinawa, Japan

They all gave the correct answers of: Tiger Woods, Fleet Street, the company, the forum and Eine kleine Nachtmusik. The theme was musicals by Stephen Sondheim: Into the Woods, Sweeney Todd: the Demon Barber of Fleet Street, Company, A Funny Thing Happened on the Way to the Forum, and A Little Night Music (the English translation of Eine kleine Nachtmusik).

The questions were:

Monday: What sportsman's first names are actually Eldrick Tont?

Tuesday: Although British newspapers are no longer produced there, which London road was famous as the home of the press?

Wednesday: What is a common name for the Central Intelligence Agency?

Thursday: Which Roman tourist spot contains the Arch of Titus and the Temple of Antoninus and Faustina?

Friday: The Serenade No 13 in G Major by Mozart is popularly known by what name?

*A smile is the chosen vehicle of all
ambiguities.*

Herman Melville